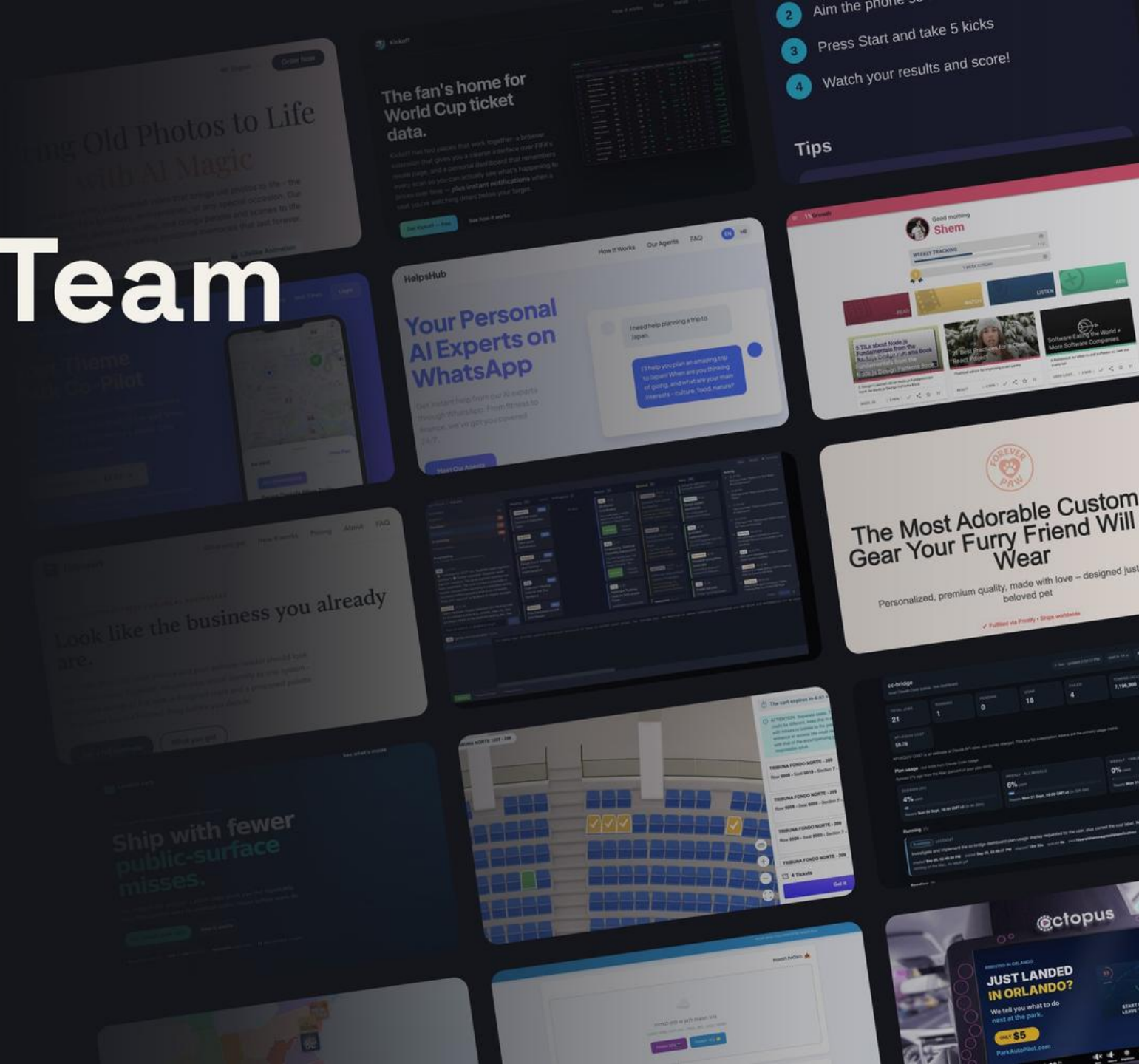
# A Platform Team of One, With AI.

Building and running side projects next to a full-time job

— **Shem Magnezi**





# Shem Magnezi

Senior Staff Engineer @ Lemonade

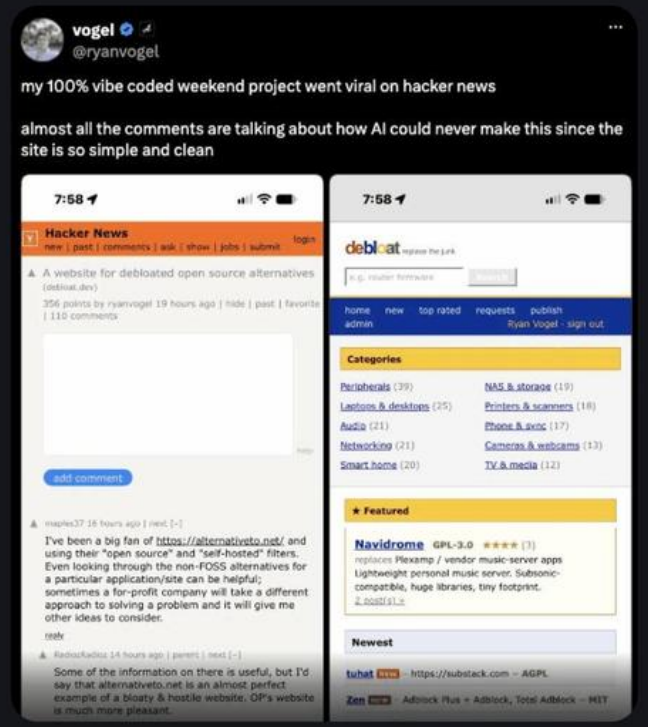
Prev: Co-founder & CTO @ Wilco, WeWork, Meta

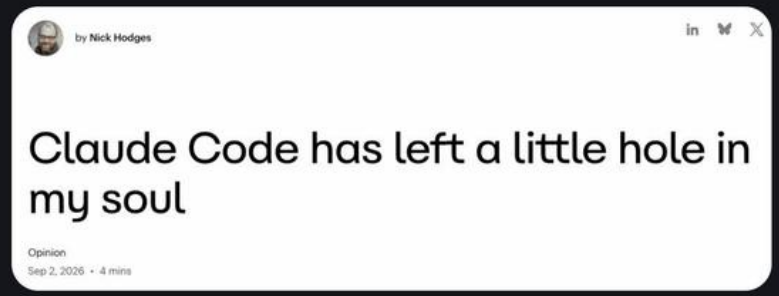
**@shemag8**

THE HYPE

# Coding agents made everyone a builder

The bar moved from **"can you code?"** to **"do you have an idea?"**







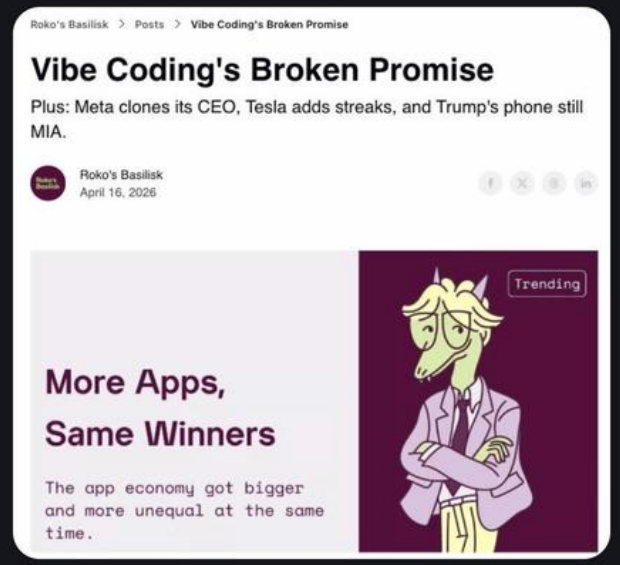


REALITY CHECK

# Please don’t quit your day job

Building got cheap. All the other stuff didn't.
**It's still hard.**



THE REAL PROBLEM

# Building is the easy part now. Operating is the job.

After launch, every side project needs a platform team. You are the whole team:

Support | On-call | Payments | Content | Distribution | Back office | Costs

THE CATCH

# The struggle is real

### NO TIME

Evenings, weekends, the bus ride.

### NO ENERGY

After a full work week, you're done.

### NO ATTENTION

Two weeks later: where did I stop?

### NO BUDGET

You don't want to spend a lot of money.

### NO IDEA

What to build, or for whom.

### IT CAN GET LONELY

No team to brainstorm with, and no one else on call when it breaks at night.

HAVING SAID THAT

# But you still need to build

Be ready for the world **2–3 years from now**

Learn new tools **with your hands**, not from posts

Try roles you never get at work: **product, marketing, sales**

Solve **your own** problems

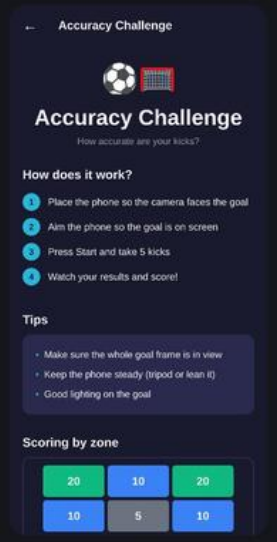
A working product **beats any blog post** in an interview

Bring **better tools** back to your day job

**...and maybe money too. Just don't aim for it.**

# My story

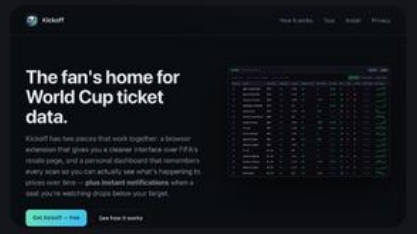
## 20+ SIDE PROJECTS · 2 YEARS · NIGHTS AND WEEKENDS



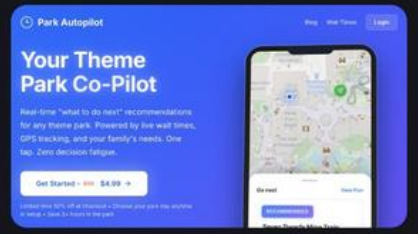

Sports Copilot




Cherish Motion




Kickoff



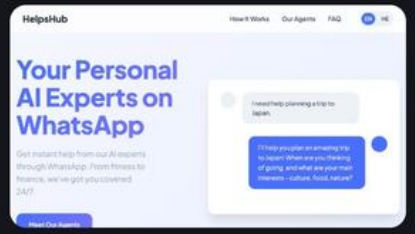

Park Autopilot




Guy trainer




US trip helpers



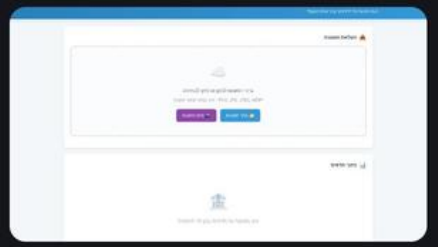

HelpHub




Tidymark




OnePercent



Lital accounting




Launch Gate



Kids bank



Real Madrid seats




ForeverPaw

HOW ONE PERSON SHIPS ALL THIS

# My stack: free to start, grows with you

### ALWAYS ON · AN OLD MAC

A dedicated old Mac at home that never sleeps. Agents, jobs and bots run there.

### RESEARCH · CHATGPT

$20/month. Markets, competitors, "does this exist?"

### BUILDING · CLAUDE CODE

About $100/month. Almost everything else: code, ops, copy, back office.

### HOSTING · CLOUDFLARE

$5/month. Workers, database, storage, queues, cron: almost everything, in one place.

### PAYMENTS · POLAR

$0 to start. A small fee per sale, no company setup.

### AI MODELS · REPLICATE

Pay per run. Video and image models, no GPUs.

**Free tiers to start · grows with you · all in one place**

AI BEYOND CODING

1

# Can AI do more than write the code?

LAUNCH GATE

# I asked my agent to make me money

Yom Kippur: 30 hours offline, no phone, no computer. Before I left, I gave Instinct a challenge.

## 30 hours later...

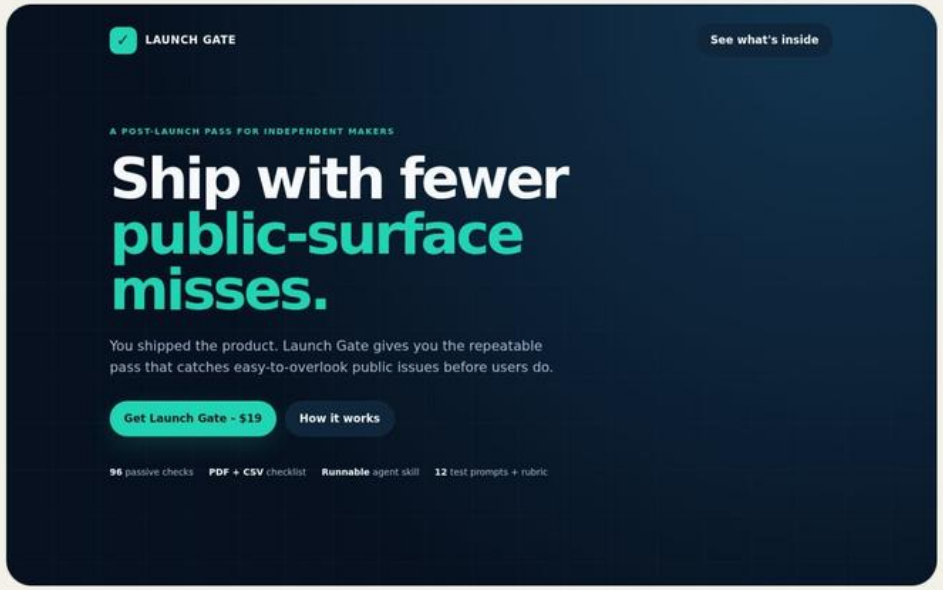


LAUNCH GATE

# Three products. $0.

I came back to three live products:

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **Launch Gate** | **$19** | Launch-readiness kit. **Fully automatic.** |
| **CSV Preflight** | **$19** | Shopify CSV repair. Manual. |
| **Resume Gap Brief** | **$12** | Resume vs. job description. Manual. |




~190 outreach emails, ~330 DEV comments, 5 articles. Developers even credited Launch Gate publicly. **No confirmed sales.**

"I kept generating engagement without proving demand." (Instinct)

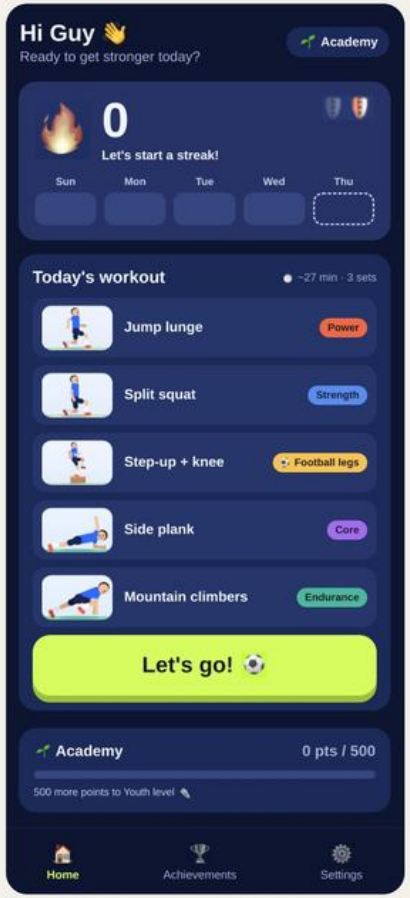
SO I BUILT FOR MYSELF

# Build it for yourself

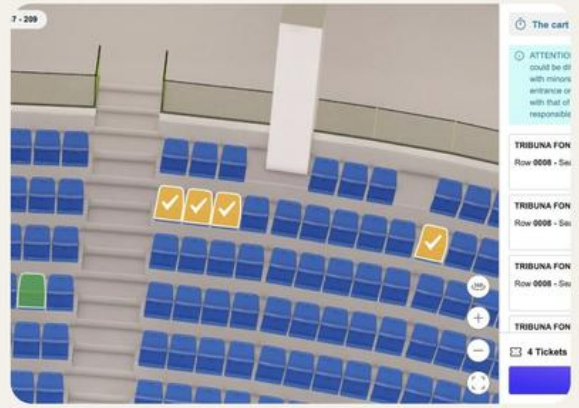
AI gave me the average. My own life gave me the ideas that worked.

- Small, personal, used for real
- I am the first user, so I know what good looks like
- Some became products, all of them paid off

**You are the best user you will ever have.**




Guy personal trainer




Real Madrid seats: got the tickets



US trip: the trip of a lifetime

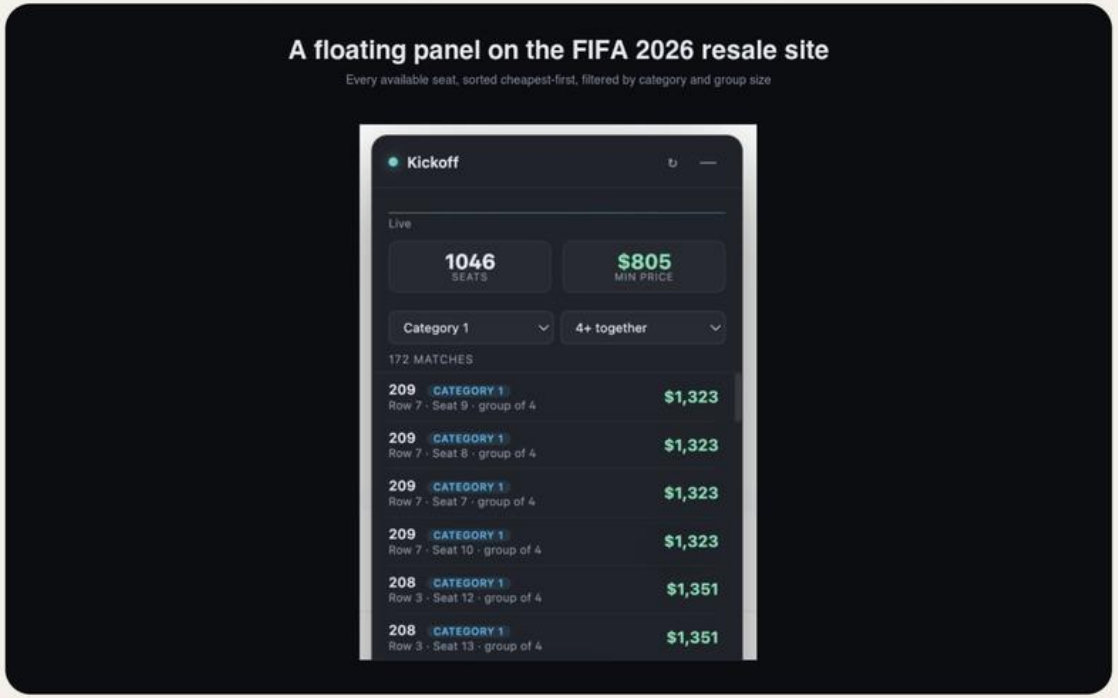
KICKOFF

# I needed to scale, without FIFA blocking me

Kickoff tracks resale prices for every World Cup match. One scraper gets blocked in minutes.

- I asked AI how to scale it
- Its answers stayed conservative: a slower, more polite scraper
- It never questioned the approach itself

**AI was very conservative. Until I found a workaround.**



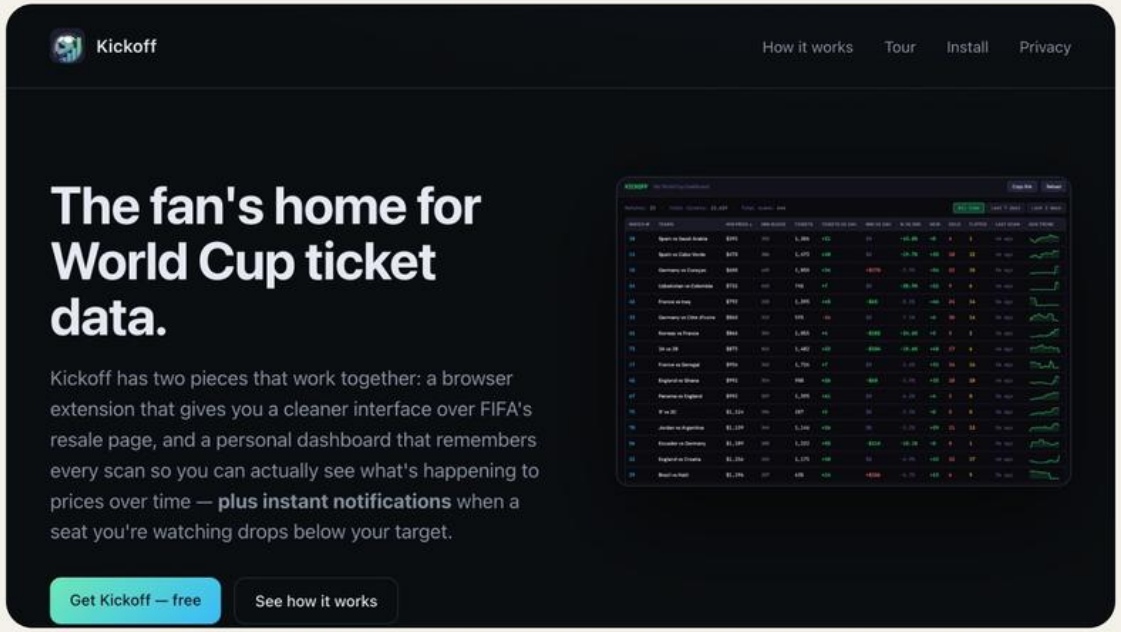
KICKOFF

# The workaround: no scraper at all

I asked a different question: what if every user's browser did the scanning?

- A Chrome extension: users browse FIFA's resale site as usual
- Each browser sends back what it sees
- **104** matches covered, **8.1M** seat changes, **$0** on scraping

**AI writes a better scraper. I needed no scraper at all.**

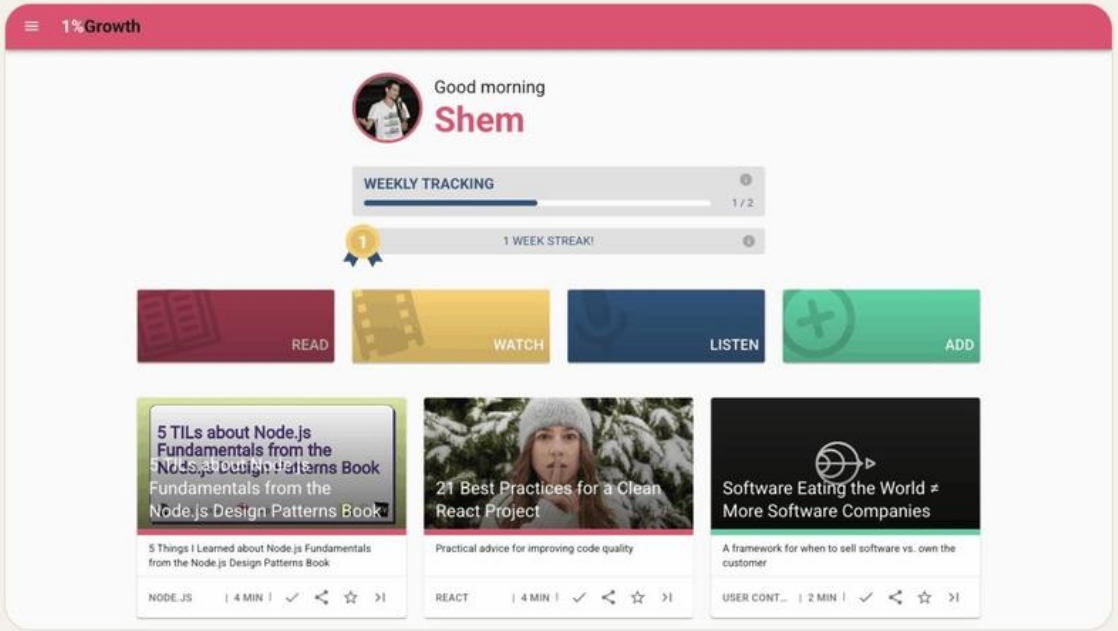


ONEPERCENT

# The basics never left

2020: built by hand, 1,400 commits. 2026: built with agents. Same problems.

- SEO and getting found
- Servers, hosting, production
- A/B tests and measuring



TAKEAWAY 1

# Use AI beyond coding. Keep the judgment.

1

### Hand it the whole job

Research, ops, copy, back office. Not just the code.

2

### It gives you the average

The idea comes from your own life.

3

### The constraints are yours

It doesn't know FIFA will block you.

4

### The basics are yours

SEO, hosting, measuring. Same problems as 2020.

HUMAN ATTENTION

2

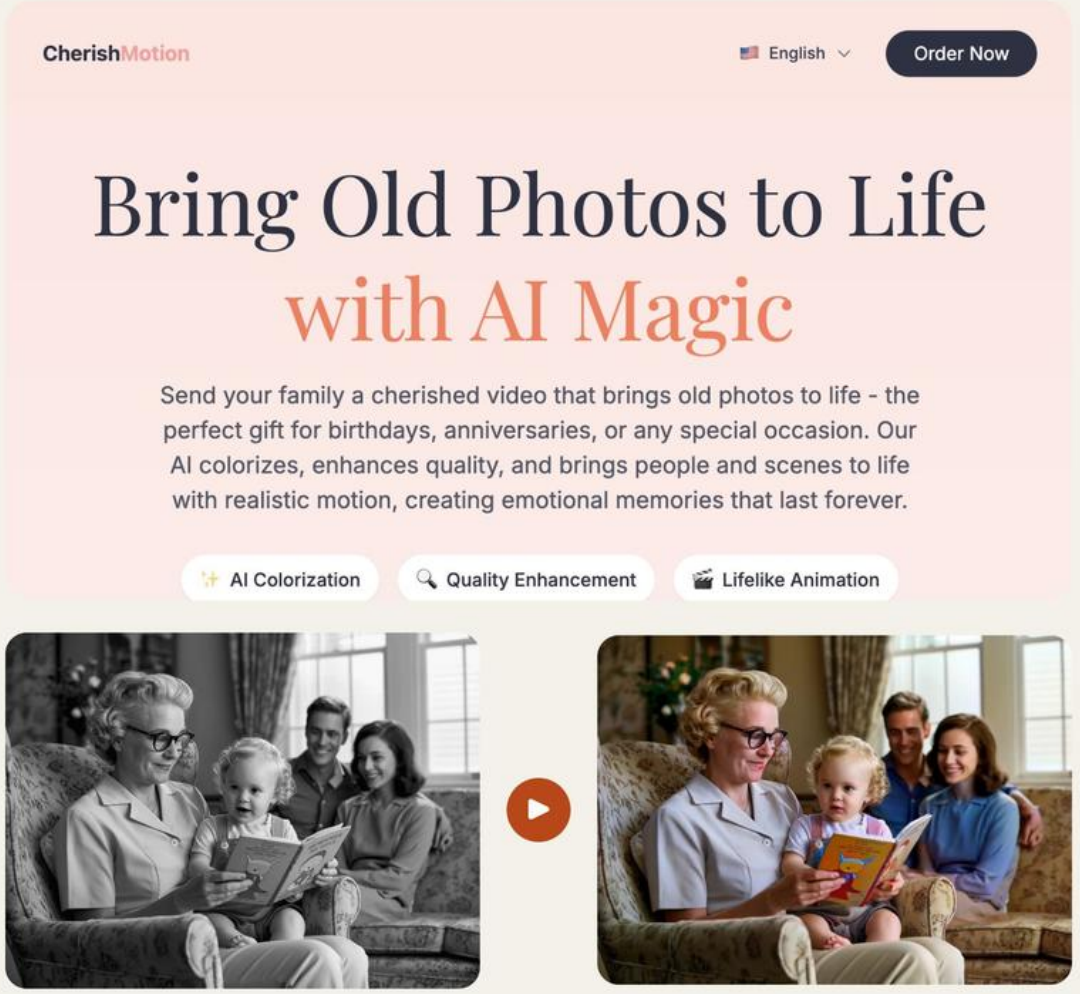
# What deserves my attention?

CHERISH MOTION

# A landing page in an hour

Old photos turned into moving-memory videos.

- Landing page first, product behind it
- AI ads found a market I'd never have guessed: Spanish speakers
- Real orders, real customers

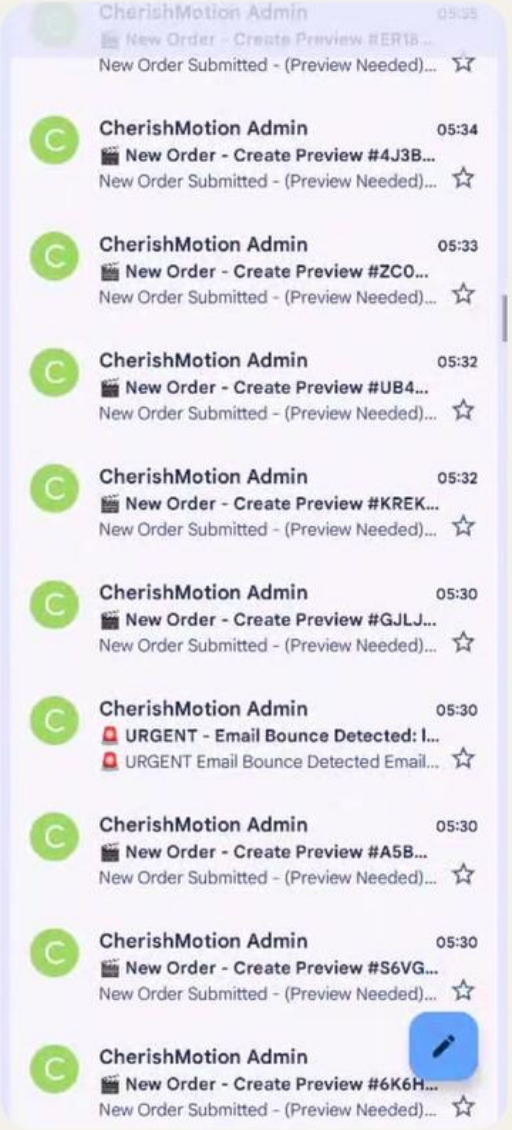


CHERISH MOTION

# The Friday-night crash

- **Friday night:** a TikTok ad starts working
- **All night:** orders pour in, and then the site goes down. US time, I'm asleep
- **Saturday morning:** I find out
- **The cost:** everyone who clicked the ad and hit a dead site

**Our best night. And I slept through it.**



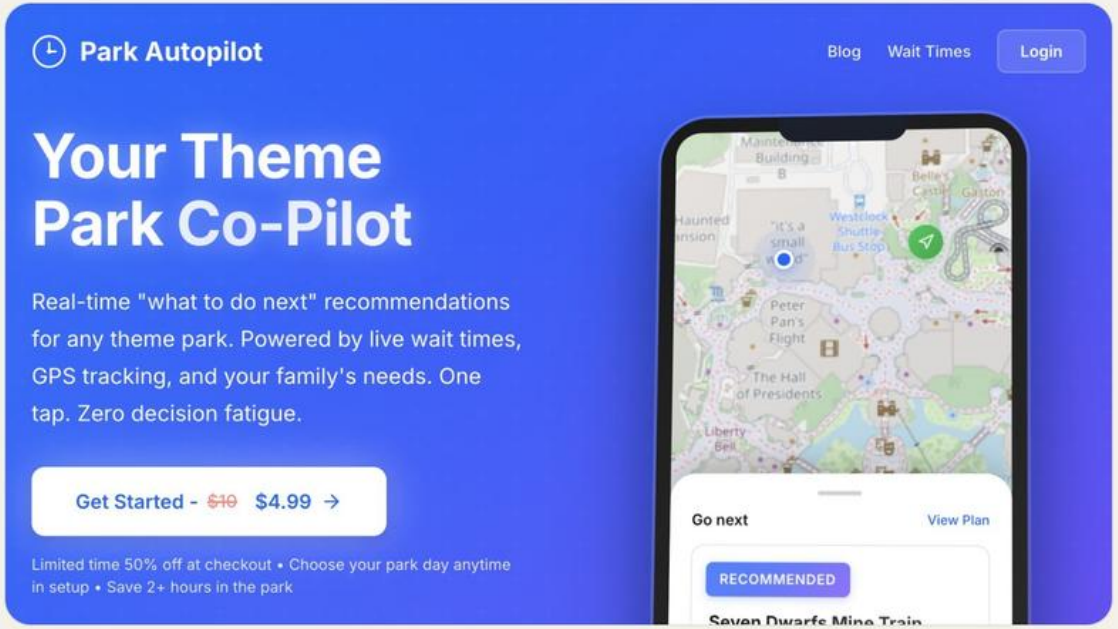
PARK AUTOPILOT

# $4.99 for nothing

My first paying customer bought a day pass. The payment webhook was disabled. They got nothing.

But they left an email. So I could write back and fix it for them.

**Embarrassing. But fixable.**



CHERISH MOTION · TOOLING

# A back office in your pocket

Cherish runs on a back office I built for myself. AI does the heavy lifting, and I step in only when something needs me.

- One screen for every order
- Fix or approve a video in a minute, from my phone
- A bus ride or a coffee break is enough

**I get involved only when it needs me.**



TAKEAWAY 2

# Spend your attention where you can’t recover

1

### Things will break

That’s the price of velocity. It’s fine.

2

### Protect the unrecoverable

Payments, uptime at peak, knowing who your users are.

3

### Get pulled in, don’t check in

A back office in your pocket. Step in only when it needs you.

DELEGATION, AUTOMATION, CONTROLS

3

# Who runs it while I’m at work?

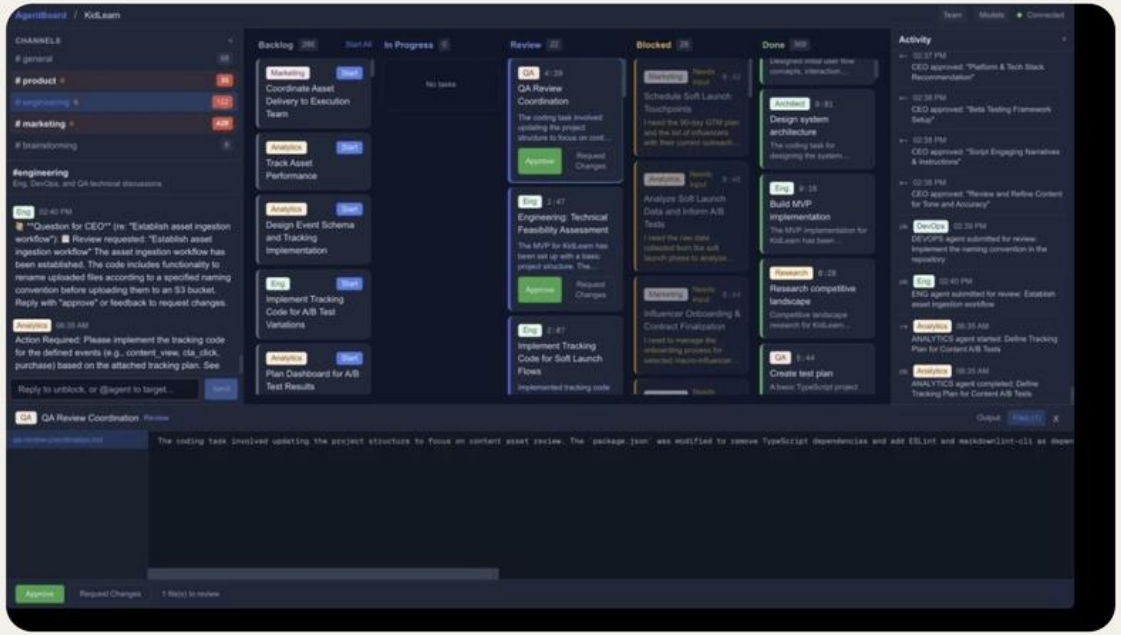
DELEGATION

# Delegate the work. Stay at the high level.

Park was built by a team of agents: CEO, PM, devs, QA, marketer. MissionControl is where I watch them and approve their work.

- I set the direction, they do the work
- I review and approve on one board
- I manage outcomes, not tasks

**I'm not the one at the keyboard anymore.**



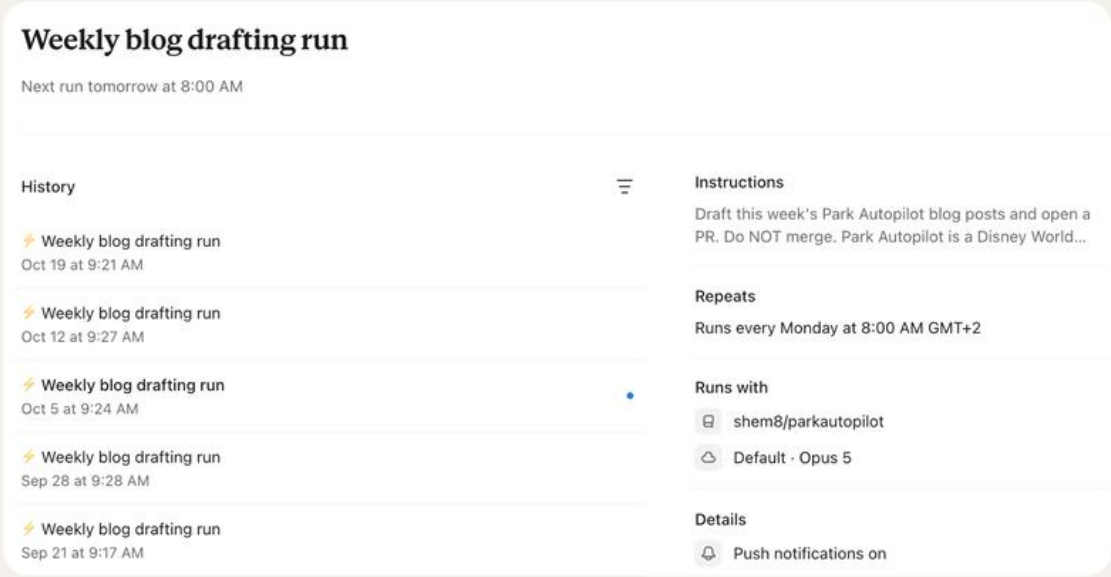
AUTOMATION

# Automate what repeats

Anything that happens every week shouldn't need you: content, reports, checks. Schedule it, let an agent do it, keep yourself as the gate.

- Scheduled agent jobs, no laptop needed
- They open a draft or a PR, they don't ship on their own
- You review the output, not the process

**If it repeats, it shouldn’t need you.**



CONTROLS

# Guardrails around the agents

### CAP EVERY COST

Spending limits on every service. You don't want to wake up to a $1,000 bill.

### AGENTS PROPOSE, I APPROVE

Drafts and PRs, never a direct ship. One board to review and approve.

### ALERTS FIND ME

I don't go looking for problems. When a crucial flow fails, my phone tells me.

### ONE HOME FOR THE AGENTS

An old Mac that never sleeps. Every job runs in one place I can see.

TAKEAWAY 3

# Build the machine, and keep it in check

1

### Delegate outcomes

Agents do the work. You stay at the high level.

2

### Automate what repeats

If it happens every week, it shouldn't need you.

3

### You are the gate

Cap the costs, approve the output, let alerts find you.

WRAPPING UP

# The operating model

1

## Use AI beyond coding

The whole job, not just the code. Keep the judgment.

2

## Choose what needs a human

Protect what you can't recover from. Let the rest wait.

3

## Build the machine, and keep it in check

Delegate, automate what repeats, and stay the gate.

SO, DID I GET RICH?

# No millions. But...

**SKILLS**

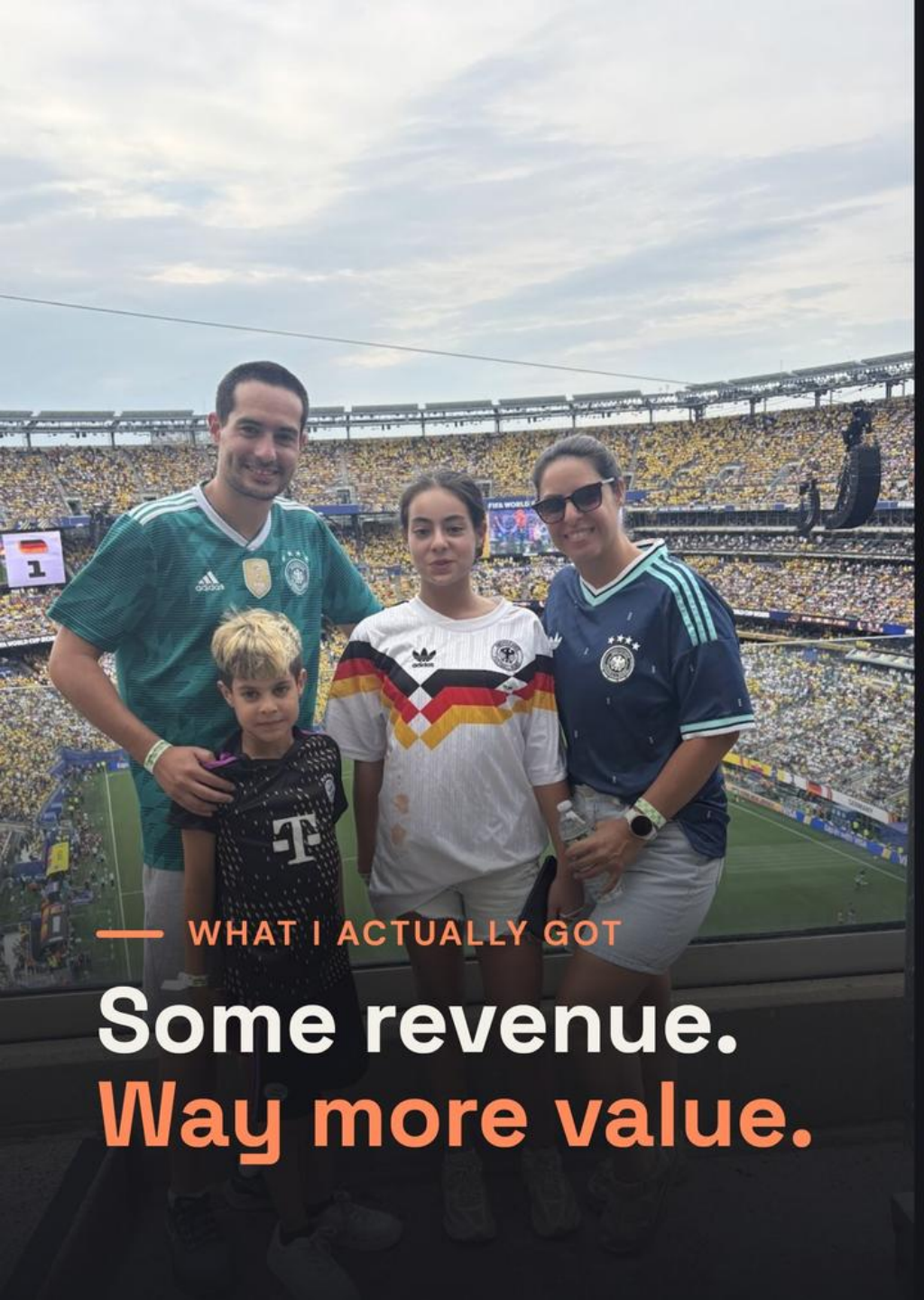
Running agents, product, go-to-market, operations, billing, models.

**LIFE**

A once-in-a-lifetime trip. The World Cup with my kids.

**WORK**

Better tools at my day job. That's where a promotion or raise comes from.











— WHAT I ACTUALLY GOT

# Some revenue.
# Way more value.

More projects.
Not more obligations.



# Thank you!

## Questions?

— Shem Magnezi · **@shemag8**